RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

The Torah Will Not Change: Principles 8 & 9

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 14

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: the close of Principle 8 (*Torah min HaShamayim*) and Principle 9 (the Torah will never be abrogated)

Shiur: Part 14 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 20 January 2026

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Announcements

- **Monday nights, from 2 February:** the ***HaMaspik LeOvdei Hashem*** (*The Sufficient Guide to Serving Hashem*) of **the Rambam's son**, "a fascinating book."
- **Tuesday nights, after the Thirteen Principles:** the ***Moreh Nevuchim***, the Rambam's *Guide for the Perplexed*.

Recap: Where We Are

Principles	Theme
1–5	**What Hashem is and isn't**
6–7	**Hashem's relationship with humanity through prophecy**, to unique individuals, and **Moshe's unique prophecy**
8	**Revelation *en masse***, to all of Am Yisrael: **the Torah we have is the Torah given to Moshe 3,300 years ago**
9	Tonight: **the fourth and final principle of revelation**

Part 1: Principle 8 Summed Up

#	Point	The Rabbi
1	**Our Torah is Moshe's Torah**	The **script** may have changed; ***keri u-ketiv*** and ***chaserot u-melot*** inconsistencies **are acknowledged by Chazal**. "**But the actual text is the same text.**"
2	**Entirely *min HaShamayim*: dictated by Hashem to Moshe**; no autonomous authorship, **not Moshe's, not anyone's after**	**Biblical criticism**, the old academic theory of **four documents compiled together**, "**now really shelved by most**," is **complete *kefirah***. (The Gemara entertains **Yehoshua** for **the last eight verses**; **Ibn Ezra** and some Rishonim felt **one or two words** perhaps weren't. "But generally speaking, it's the same Torah.")
3	**All equally holy**	Some parts **contain more principles**: you wouldn't learn the Torah's principles from **the kings of Edom** rather than the **Ten Commandments** or **Shema**. "**That's fine to say.**" **Not that one is holier**
4	**The Oral Torah is part of it**	Below

"The beauty of our Torah": through **exile to the four corners of the earth**, **Sephardim, Ashkenazim, Chassidim, Teimanim, Italians, Spanish and Portuguese**, all with different customs, rites and rituals, **the text of the Torah is identical**.

The Ten Commandments in the Temple

"**Already in the Beit HaMikdash** they said **the Ten Commandments every day**, and **it was cancelled**, because people began **ascribing more holiness** to them than the rest of the Torah." **Fundamentals that contain everything else: yes. Holier: no.**

The Oral Torah: the class-notes analogy

"You go to a class and **take notes**. **You** understand them because **you heard the class**; **others won't**. **The Torah is Moshe's notes from Hashem**, complemented by **the oral tradition**."

Verse	What only the Oral Torah tells you
והיו לטטפת בין עיניך	**What are *totafot*?**
בסכת תשבו שבעת ימים	**What's a sukkah? Its dimensions? How many walls?** (***Halachah leMoshe miSinai***)

Accepting the full divinity and importance of the written Torah while denying the Oral Torah is still a denial of Principle 8. That was **the Karaites' error** (***Kara'im***, from ***Mikra***, the written text): "**considered *kefirah***."

Part 2: Why We Believe: The Kuzari's Proof

(Rav Saadia Gaon gives it in brief; Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi develops it.)

The King of the Khazars asks: *why should I believe your religion over the others?*

אנכי ה׳ אלהיך אשר הוצאתיך מארץ מצרים

Why "who took you out of Egypt" and not "who created heaven and earth"? Surely creation is greater!

Because no one was there at creation to testify. But the Exodus, **you saw**.

The argument

Audience	Can a claim of shared revelation be faked?
10, 20, 100 people	"**A highly charismatic** leader might **pull the wool over their eyes**: *you forgot, but I took you out of Egypt*. **There are cults** that do all kinds of things"
600,000 men aged 20–60, so with children, elderly and women **about two million** ("whether exact or not doesn't matter")	**No.** "**The only religion that claimed, and has claimed ever since, a revelation *en masse***"

Shemot 19:4: אתם ראיתם אשר עשיתי למצרים, ואשא אתכם על כנפי נשרים ואבא אתכם אלי.

Rashi: אתם ראיתם — לא מסורת היא בידכם, לא בדברים אני משגר אתכם, לא בעדים אני מעמיד לכם, אלא אתם ראיתם.

Not a tradition handed to you, not words I send you, not witnesses I bring: *you saw*.

"**Other religions have always claimed God appeared to *the leader*, *their prophet*, *individuals*.** To make this claim to a whole people, **it has to be true**."

And it's a book to your detriment:

"Until you receive it, **you could strike a match on the seventh day**. **Now you'll be stoned for it. Who would accept that when they didn't hear it themselves?**"

"Perhaps someone later said your ancestors saw it?"

The unbroken chain. In **the Introduction to Mishneh Torah** (which we learned together) the Rambam lists the generations: "**only a hundred-plus generations**, and we know **who each one was**, historically. **When could it have been added? Who would have accepted it?**"

The Ramban: אין אדם מנחיל שקר לבניו: **no one bequeaths a lie to his children**, something **demonstrably false**.

Part 3: Principle 9: The Text

היסוד התשיעי: הביטול. והוא שזאת תורת משה לא תבטל, ולא תבא תורה מאת ה׳ זולתה, ולא יתוסף בה ולא יגרע ממנה, לא בכתב ולא בפירוש, שנאמר: לא תסף עליו ולא תגרע ממנו. וכבר בארנו מה שצריך לבאר ביסוד הזה בהקדמת החבור הזה.

- **This Torah of Moshe will never be nullified.**
- **No other Torah will come from Hashem.**
- **Nothing added, nothing removed**, **neither Written nor Oral**: **לא תסף עליו ולא תגרע ממנו** (Va'etchanan, Re'eh).

- "**We've already explained this**": earlier in the Introduction, **a prophet who comes to add is put to death**; "the Rambam went into great detail."

The censored text

"Read **the square brackets, not the round ones**. **Start with *HaBitul: abrogation."***

Because of Christendom this was considered offensive, so it was changed (the round brackets) to a version saying the Torah is from Hashem, "but that's just Principle 8." "We know from the original manuscripts that the correct text is the second one. It was censored: the whole basis of Christianity is that the Torah has been abrogated*: the Brit Chadashah***, *Yirmiyahu's 'new covenant'*, the basis of the New Testament***."

Two distinct parts

	Part A	Part B
Claim	**The Torah is eternal**: never superseded by **another Torah or faith**	**The laws within the Torah never change**
Rejects	**Christianity and Islam**, which didn't deny revelation to Israel but claimed **a new revelation, through Jesus or Muhammad**, overtaking it	**Adding to or subtracting from** individual laws
Note	"**Arguably the primary part**"	"**They don't necessarily follow from each other.** I could accept no new faith **and still** allow change **within** Judaism. **The Rambam holds both**: since Hashem doesn't let the whole Torah change, **every individual law is immutable**"

Ani Ma'amin and Yigdal: Part A only

	Text
Ani Ma'amin	**שזאת התורה לא תהא מוחלפת, ולא תהא תורה אחרת מאת הבורא יתברך שמו**
Yigdal	**לא יחליף האל ולא ימיר דתו, לעולמים לזולתו**

Neither mentions that each law is immutable.

Part 4: Part A: No Other Torah

"**This is why we find the term *'Old Testament'* offensive.** It implies there's an old one and **a new one**, which isn't true."

Yirmiyahu 31: "the new covenant"

הנה ימים באים נאם ה׳ וכרתי את בית ישראל ואת בית יהודה ברית חדשה... כי זאת הברית אשר אכרת את בית ישראל אחרי הימים ההם נאם ה׳: נתתי את תורתי בקרבם ועל לבם אכתבנה, והייתי להם לאלהים והם יהיו לי לעם.

"The most famous so-called proof for the New Testament, and so easily refuted." (Rav Saadia already dealt with it in ***Emunot veDe'ot***: "**from the beginning, a contentious point**.")

#	The verses say	So
1	With ***Beit Yisrael and Beit Yehudah***	**Not for the whole world**
2	**נתתי את תורתי בקרבם**	**The same Torah**: *My* Torah, put within them
3	In that time **war will cease**	**Not 2,000 years ago**: wars continued then and **till today**
4	**כה אמר ה׳ נתן שמש לאור יומם, חקת ירח וכוכבים לאור לילה... אם ימשו החקים האלה מלפני... גם זרע ישראל ישבתו מהיות גוי לפני כל הימים**	As the **sun, moon and stars** endure, so **Israel endures as a nation**: **the Torah won't change**

So what is the *Brit Chadashah*? All the commentators: **a covenant renewed so it's never broken again**, **in the times of Mashiach**: **a new loyal bond** between Hashem and Am Yisrael.

And logically: Christians and Muslims **accept** that God gave the Torah **before 600,000 men**. "**If He wanted to change it, why reveal Himself one-on-one to Jesus, one-on-one to Muhammad? Surely He'd call everyone together again**, as He did at the beginning."

Spot the difference

The Rabbi read two texts aloud: "Bonus if you can tell me where it's from. The prize? An extra five minutes of shiur at the end."

Text 1	Text 2
God has spoken to mankind in many languages: **through Judaism to Jews, Christianity to Christians, Islam to Muslims**. God is the God of all humanity, but **no single faith is or should be the faith of all humanity**.	God communicates in human language, but **there are dimensions of the divine that must forever elude us**. As Jews we believe **God has made a covenant with a singular people**, but that **does not exclude the possibility of other peoples, cultures and faiths finding their own relationship with God** within the shared frame of **the Noahide laws**. God is the God of all humanity, but between Babel and the end of days no single faith is the faith of all humanity.

Robert: *"The first acknowledges that Christians and Muslims have some sort of prophecy; the second doesn't."*

"**Excellent. That is the key difference.**"

Both by Rabbi Jonathan Sacks, *The Dignity of Difference*, **2002**. **Text 1**: the **first edition, August 2002**. "**A huge uproar, understandably**": it suggests **God spoke through Christianity and Islam**, and that they are **equal to Judaism**. **Rabbi Rakow** *zichrono livrachah*, **Rav of Gateshead**, called the book **heresy and a deviation from authentic tradition**, and demanded he **repudiate it and withdraw it**. **Rabbi Sacks backed down**; **the revised edition, end of 2002**, has **Text 2**.

The issue: Text 1 implies **revelation to other faiths**: **against this principle**. "He was clearly **trying to be diplomatic**."

Text 2 is fine. "*Dimensions that elude us*" = **I can't explain why God appeared only to the Jews.** Other faiths **finding their own relationship with God**: "**The Rambam basically said that**: Hashem **allowed Christianity and Islam to bring people closer to God**. **They believe in a God; that's great. But you cannot acknowledge that God revealed Himself to them.**"

Part 5: Part B: The Laws Don't Change

1. Values and attitude

"**This is why we're so opposed to Reform and Conservative**: changing the Torah's laws **to fit the society we live in**, the **liberal ideas of each century**, goes against **9B**."

But: interpretation and attitude can change between generations, **not the law itself**. "**God forbid the Torah itself ever changes.** What **can** change is **our attitude to people who don't observe all of it**."

Question: *Eliyahu on Har HaCarmel* brought a sacrifice outside the Temple. Did the law change, or was it a *hora'at sha'ah*?

"**That's what the Rambam meant by 'we've already explained this.'**"

A verified prophet says…	Response
"This once", e.g. **sacrifice outside**, or **break this Shabbat and go somewhere**	**We must listen.** A *zaken* who refuses, "**how can we break Shabbat?**", **is put to death as a *zaken mamre***: rebelling against the prophet
"Shabbat no longer applies, forever"	**We don't listen, and he is put to death**
Anything involving *avodah zarah*	**Never**, not even once

"All learnt in the Gemara, accepted by all."

Follow-up: *Fire came from heaven: so Hashem accepted it?* "**Clearly. Of course.**" *But do we learn the rule independently, or from this story, "marking our own homework"?*

"**Once you're verified as a *navi*, anything you say from Hashem is accepted.** Where exactly it stems from, **I can't remember. We'll put it for another time.**"

2. The Sanhedrin's power to reinterpret

"**Controversial, but sourced.** Not everyone accepts it, but **we have *Chachamim who say it: the Supreme Court can reinterpret the Torah."***

***Example:** ayin tachat ayin**. *Read without the Oral Torah:* *your eye for my eye**. **Bava Kamma** spends **two full pages, about eight arguments**, showing it means **money**: **the value of the eye**, however assessed.

3. Why can't a law change? Rav Yosef Albo (*Sefer Halkkarim*)

Proposed reason	Albo's verdict
Hashem doesn't change, so neither should His Torah	**Rejected**
Torah is *emet*, and truth is eternal	**Rejected**

Why rejected: laws *do* change within the Torah itself. Adam was given **כל ירק עשב... לאכלה**: **no meat**. **After the Flood**, meat was permitted.

"**Hashem doesn't change, but the patient does. A doctor changes the prescription** when the patient's diet and lifestyle change."

Albo's answer: the Torah was given **directly, *en masse***, so **how could we know a change came from Hashem?** Only two ways:

Route	Possible?
A prophet greater than the original one	**No**: **Moshe is the greatest**
Evidence as convincing as, or more than, the original	**Theoretically yes**

"So for Albo, **if three million people again claimed a mass revelation telling them *don't keep Shabbat***, **seemingly the law would change**. *Why shouldn't Hashem add or diminish as His wisdom decrees?* **I don't think the Rambam would agree.**"

4. Rabbinic additions: *bal tosif*

How could the rabbis add so many mitzvot? The Torah forbids **meat and milk**; **Chazal added poultry**.

The Rambam (Hilchot Mamrim 2:9): "A court may **decree a prohibition** on something permitted, **binding for generations**. What then is *do not add, do not detract*? **They may not add to the Torah's words or detract from them *as if it were scriptural law. The Torah forbids cooking and eating meat and milk; fowl in milk is permitted by Torah law. If the court says fowl in milk is permitted, but **we forbid it as a decree***: **that's allowed**. It's **a safeguard**, not an addition."

Says	Status
"**The Torah permits chicken and milk; we forbid it as a fence**"	**Permitted**: a *gezeirah*
"**The Torah forbids chicken and milk**"	**Violates *bal tosif***

"**That's why throughout the Gemara: *d'Oraita* or *d'Rabbanan*?** Always **know the source**; **don't be loose in what you say.**"

5. What *will* change: Nevi'im and Ketuvim

Hilchot Megillah 2:18: כל ספרי הנביאים וכל הכתובים עתידין ליבטל לימות המשיח, חוץ ממגילת אסתר, הרי היא קיימת כחמשה חומשי תורה וכהלכות של תורה שבעל פה שאינן בטלין לעולם.

All of Nevi'im and Ketuvim will be nullified in Messianic times, except Megillat Esther, which endures **like the Five Books and the Oral Torah**.

The Ra'avad disagrees ("**you've misunderstood it**"). **But the Rambam codifies it. This principle covers only the Chumash and the Oral Torah.**

Question: *You've often said the other fasts are* **divrei kabbalah***, not quite* d'Rabbanan*. So Ta'anit Esther stays, and the others disappear?*

"**Correct. We won't do them any more. That's exactly what the Rambam is saying.**"

6. Midrashim on change in the future

Midrash Tehillim 146 (*"not clear who wrote it; apparently 8th–9th century; after the Gemara, authoritative to some extent"*), on **ה׳ מתיר אסורים**: not only **releasing the bound** (the morning *berachah*; prisoners and hostages) but **permitting the forbidden**:

> **יש אומרים: כל הבהמה שנטמאת בעולם הזה, מטהר אותה הקב״ה לעתיד לבוא**: **non-kosher animals become kosher**.

> **אין איסור גדול מן הנדה… ולעתיד לבוא הוא מתירה**: **"Why? I've got no idea.** Really quite **shocking**" **Hashem will permit *niddah*."**

Vayikra Rabbah, "**much more authoritative**," on **the sacrifices in the future**. "**No shortage** of rabbinic sources implying **some change in Messianic times**."

The Rambam doesn't imply that. He says **Nevi'im and Ketuvim** end then, but **the Chumash doesn't**: "**the thrust everywhere in the Rambam: in Messianic times, law continues, Torah continues. Kosher animals won't change.**" How he'd deal with these Midrashim, **reject or read metaphorically**: "I don't know exactly."

Shabbetai Tzvi: "**this is why the false Mashiach was so successful.** He used **these texts**: *how can you do this? —* ***Mashiach is here, so the laws can change***. **If it's Messianic times, anything can change.**"

Question: *"So in Messianic times we can eat pork?"* "**There's an opinion that says so, yes.**" *"So why not now?"* "**We're not in Messianic times.**"

Summary

1. **Principle 8: same Torah**, **wholly divine** (biblical criticism is *kefirah*), **equally holy**, **with the Oral Torah** (**the Karaites** denied it).
2. **The Kuzari's proof: אנכי… אשר הוצאתיך**: **a revelation to two million people**, **אתם ראיתם** (Rashi), an unbroken chain of **100+ generations**, **אין אדם מנחיל שקר לבניו**.
3. **Principle 9** (the **uncensored** text, ***HaBitul***): **(A) no other Torah**, rejecting **Christianity and Islam**; **(B) no individual law changes**. Ani Ma'amin and Yigdal cover only **A**.
4. **Yirmiyahu's *Brit Chadashah*** is refuted from its own verses; **Rabbi Sacks's** *Dignity of Difference* revision shows the line: **other faiths may relate to God; they did not receive revelation**.
5. **Part B:** attitudes and interpretation shift, laws don't (**Reform/Conservative**); **a prophet may suspend, never abolish** (**Eliyahu**); the **Sanhedrin** reinterprets (***ayin tachat ayin***); **Albo** grounds immutability in **the evidence of mass revelation**; **rabbinic fences** must be labelled ***d'Rabbanan***.
6. **Nevi'im and Ketuvim** (except **Esther**) end in Messianic times (**the Rambam vs the Ra'avad**); **Midrashim of future change** are **at odds with the Rambam**, and **fuelled Shabbetai Tzvi**.

Coming Up

Next week: Principle 10: Hashem knows the deeds of human beings, the start of **the final category, reward and punishment**.

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